

CUT SHORT
A TV grab of Atiq and his brother Ashraf seconds before they were gunned down in Prayagraj

It's also a battle that the chief minister has been waging ever since he came to power in the country's most populous state in March 2017 with a blueprint that has been evolving and attaining a dual layer of sophistication not always visible on the surface. At one level, like the tough-talking, straight-shooting sheriffs of popular lore, the saffron-clad Yogi's police force has written a penal code marked out by bullets—on April 13 in Jhansi, Atiq's son Asad Ahmed became the 183rd criminal to be killed in an 'encounter' with the police. In a policy that went hand in hand, the state government has also seized and demolished property worth over Rs 2,500 crore said to be illegally acquired by gangsters.

CRACKING DOWN ON THE GANGS OF UP

Even as he unleashed 'zero tolerance' against criminal gangs, Yogi also pursued a more textbook version of justice that has gathered pace in his second term. Behind the gunsmoke and the dust raised by bulldozers, he put into motion an overhaul of the entire police force, judicial system and state administration. Over the decades, a vast netherworld of crime had entrenched itself in the state around a builder-contractor-mafia nexus with corrupt officials in police and administra-

THE LIFE & CRIMES OF ATIQ AHMED

In the badlands of Uttar Pradesh, Atiq Ahmed was Don No. 1. With as many as 101 cases lodged against him, including under the stringent National Security Act, he evoked intense fear among people in and around Prayagraj (formerly Allahabad) for over four decades. So much so that in 2012, 10 judges reportedly recused themselves from hearing his bail plea, which he needed to fight the assembly election from Allahabad West as an Apna Dal candidate. The 11th judge granted him bail, but Ahmed lost the poll to Puja Pal, the widow of BSP MLA Raju Pal who had challenged the gangster's grip over the constituency in